

an instant access and immediate notification of deals, both in the stores and online. Unfortunately for my budget, I temporarily became a marketer's best friend, ripe for the picking as an isolated, homeschooling mother of six. I was particularly vulnerable to the peer pressure environment of a refunding website where everyone raved about that day's "good deals" on the boards—something I'd never encountered with a monthly magazine—where the majority of the deals were already over by the time I'd read about them. Suddenly I had instant access to good deals. I could read about a product being clearanced on the shelves of a chain store in the morning and rush to the nearest one that very afternoon to see if our area was having the same deal. I'd hear through the group grapevine the timing of Target's after-Christmas "75% off" sale and, with kids in tow, head there an hour before it opened so I could be first in line for the drastically discounted Christmas decorations, paper, perfume sets, and holiday flannel sheet sets. As for the online offers, I'm afraid I succumbed to the hype for a few months, as I pulled out my brand new charge card to cover the handling fees and shipping charges on the many new customer introductory code offers. The small charges added up rapidly, and I actually felt a little sick to my stomach the day the UPS truck delivered two Rubbermaid toy boxes and three laundry baskets from a deal that seemed too good to pass up. (On a side note, those toy boxes went through thirteen years and three children intact, so perhaps they really did constitute a good deal.) I abruptly came to my senses one day when I found myself considering the purchase of ten drastically-reduced cashmere sweaters—I don't even wear sweaters!